

A **Virtual Private Network (VPN)** allows you to use the internet safely by creating a **secure, encrypted tunnel** between your device and a VPN server. When you connect to public WiFi at a coffee shop, the WiFi network is part of a **Wide Area Network (WAN)** that connects your device to the internet.

Without a VPN, the data you send to apps like **Spotify** or **YouTube** travels over the public WAN and could be intercepted by attackers on the same network. With a VPN enabled, all your internet traffic is **encrypted** before it leaves your device. This encrypted data travels through the public WAN to the VPN server, where it is decrypted and then forwarded to the destination (such as Spotify or YouTube). The response follows the same secure path back to your device.

This process creates a **private tunnel** over the public WAN, making it much harder for hackers, WiFi owners, or other users on the network to view your online activity or steal sensitive information.

- Your laptop connects to the coffee shop's public WiFi.
- You turn on your VPN app.
- The VPN creates an **encrypted tunnel** through the public WAN to a VPN server.
- You open **Spotify** or **YouTube**.
- Your requests travel securely through the VPN tunnel before reaching the app's servers.
- Anyone monitoring the public WiFi can only see encrypted data, not the websites you visit or the information you send.